

RUINSTARS

Squad Operations In A Dying Galaxy

HORDE MODE

Version 20251231



HORDE MODE

No extraction was planned. The signal was a lie, the drop zone already dead before the first boots hit ash. Now the horde is coming. Endless, relentless, testing the walls with teeth and claws and fire. Ammunition runs thin. Wounds pile up. Orders come through broken comms and half-functional consoles. Between each assault there is only enough time to drag the wounded clear, reinforce the barricades, and spend the last scraps of authority and materiel before the next wave hits harder than the last.

There is no triumph to be claimed here, only the mercy of a few stolen minutes.

Horde Mode is a solo or cooperative survival mode for Ruinstars in which one Squad fights against escalating waves of enemies. Each Wave brings new threats, stronger enemies, and unpredictable battlefield events. Players must balance aggression, positioning, resource management, and emergency recovery as the enemy pressure steadily increases. The Horde never stops coming; only brief respites between Waves allowing Units to patch wounds, recover supplies, and deploy defenses.

Unlike standard Missions, Horde Mode has no fixed objective beyond survival. Waves only end when all Horde Units are Taken Out, and difficulty steadily rises as the battle grinds on. Special Turn Events, supply drops, reinforcements, and Boss encounters ensure that no two runs play the same. Victory comes by finding how long your Squad can stand before being overwhelmed.

THE GAME CYCLE

1. Set up battlefield
2. Deploy Player Squad
3. Play Waves
 1. Spawn Horde Units
 2. Roll Wave Objective
 3. Play Turns until all Horde Units are Taken Out
 4. Spend MP and prepare for the next Wave

SET UP BATTLEFIELD

Set up the battlefield following the mission's instructions. Define player deployment zones, enemy spawn zones, and place any mission markers. See the battlefields listed below for details.

DEPLOY THE PLAYER SQUAD

Deploy all Player Units in the battlefield's deployment zone.

In Horde mode, players deploy a normal 100GP Squad. When playing cooperatively, players may choose one of the following formats:

- **Shared Squad:**

Players share control of one full 100 GP Squad. Players take turns activating Units in that Squad.

- **Mini Squads:**

Each player deploys a reduced-size Squad:

- 2 Players → 50 GP each
- 3 Players → 34 GP each
- 4 Players → 25 GP each

Notes:

- Each mini-squad may have a Leader, but their Leader effect is ignored and each mini-squad rolls **1D3** for TO.
 - Alternatively, select one mini-squad to have the sole leader, and roll TO normally (including the Leader's **Leader** x skill). In this case, all mini-squads share the obtained TO.
- Units that are in different mini-Squads are considered to be Squadmates.

DOWNED UNITS

When a Player Unit reaches zero **HIT**, do not remove it from the battlefield. Instead, set it on its side to indicate its **Downed** status. Downed Units are ignored by Horde Units, cannot be targeted in combat, and do not take any Damage.

During their activation, Downed Units may only perform the Dash action.

A Standing Unit may revive a Downed Unit it Controls (2 **ACT** Mission Action): The Downed Unit returns as Standing with 1 **HIT** remaining.

Whenever a Downed Unit is revived, it gains one random Injury. If that Injury is one that the Unit already has, the Unit is Deceased and removed from the battlefield.

If all Player Units are Downed or Deceased, the Mission ends in failure.

PLAYING A WAVE

Each Wave follows the same sequence:

1. **Spawn Horde Units**

Spawn Horde Units according to the Wave table below. Place Units starting from the primary spawn point and following the placement rules listed under Spawn.

2. **Roll Wave Objective**

Roll or select a Wave Objective (see below). This objective remains in effect for the duration of the Wave.

3. **Play Turns**

Each Wave lasts for a series of Turns until all Horde Units are Taken Out.

4. **Upgrades**

Earn the MP listed for the Wave and spend your earned MP on Upgrades (see below), then prepare for the next Wave.

TURN SEQUENCE

1. Roll Tactical Orders (TO)

2. Turn Event

For Turns 1-4 of a Wave, roll on the Turn Events table below.

For Turns 5+ of a Wave, the Turn Event is always **Enemy Reinforcements**.

3. Activations

- Player Squad always has initiative
- Activate one Player Unit
- Activate one Horde Unit. Follow that Unit's **Behavior** skill.
 - Note:** If a Horde Boss is present, it activates first
- Repeat until all Units have activated

4. End of Turn

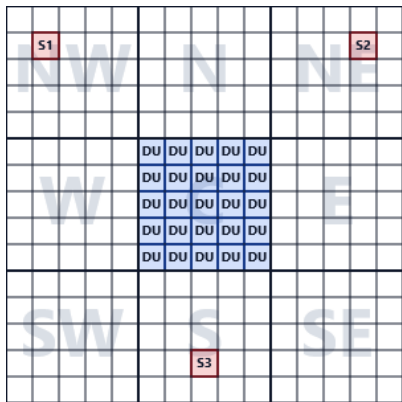
If there are no Standing Horde Units, the Wave ends.

BATTLEFIELDS

1 - THE WAR-TORN METROPOLIS

The city is already dead. We're just fighting over the remains. Towering shells of buildings loom overhead, their interiors gutted by fire and artillery, rebar jutting like so much exposed bone. The streets are choked with overturned transports, shattered armor hulks, and smoldering craters where something fell hard and did not get back up. Ash drifts through the air, stinging the eyes and clogging lungs, while distant fires cast a dull orange glow through the smoke. The ground itself is treacherous, cracked and unstable, threatening collapse under careless movement. And from every alley, breach, and shadowed ruin, the enemy pours in without end.

BATTLEFIELD DIAGRAM

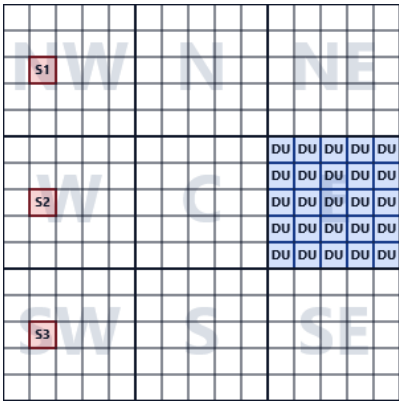


- ☐ DU Player Squad Deployment Zone
- ☐ S1 Spawn Point 1
- ☐ S2 Spawn Point 2
- ☐ S3 Spawn Point 3

2 - WEAPONS MANUFACTURE

Long corridors stretch between sealed bulkheads and shattered blast doors, lit by flickering strips of emergency lighting and the cold glow of malfunctioning consoles. Machinery hums and grinds deep within the walls, its purpose long forgotten, while coolant leaks, sparking cables, and ruptured conduits turn every approach into a hazard. On one side, the squad digs in among barricades and overturned work platforms, watching the far end of the complex with growing dread. On the other, alarms wail and containment fields fail, and something begins to move from the depths of the Facility.

BATTLEFIELD DIAGRAM



- ☐ DU Player Squad Deployment Zone
- ☐ S1 Spawn Point 1
- ☐ S2 Spawn Point 2
- ☐ S3 Spawn Point 3

SPAWNING HORDE UNITS

At the start of each wave, roll 3D6. Each die result maps to a Horde Unit and its quantity to Spawn.

For example, in Wave 5, we roll 3D6 and get 1, 3, 6. This maps to:

- 4 Ruin Stalkers (1 and 3, each mapping to 2 Ruin Stalkers)
- 1 Razorhowl Reaper (6)

When placing Spawned Units, place the first Unit Adjacent to the first Spawn point, the second Unit Adjacent to the second Spawn point, etc. If you run out of Spawn points, just start back on the first one.

For Boss Waves (4, 8, and 12), select a random Boss Unit and follow its Spawn instructions for placement and other rules. If you already fought the selected Boss in a previous Wave, re-roll until you get a Boss you haven't fought yet.

WAVE TABLE

ACT 1 - WAVES 1-4				ACT 2 - WAVES 5-8				ACT 3 - WAVES 9-12			
Wave	Roll	Spawns	MP	Wave	Roll	Spawns	MP	Wave	Roll	Spawns	MP
Wave 1	1-4	2x Carrion Leech	4	Wave 5	1-4	2x Ruin Stalker	8	Wave 9	1-4	2x Razorhowl Reaper	12
	5	2x Blight Herald			5	2x Dustborn Thrall			5	2x Last-Light Executioner	
	6	1x Ruin Stalker			6	1x Razorhowl Reaper			6	2x Last-Light Executioner	
Wave 2	1-4	2x Toxin Spitter	5	Wave 6	1-4	2x Ashline Gunner	9	Wave 10	1-4	2x Graveward Sentinel	13
	5	2x Blight Herald			5	2x Dustborn Thrall			5	2x Last-Light Executioner	
	6	1x Ashline Gunner			6	1x Graveward Sentinel			6	2x Last-Light Executioner	
Wave 3	1-2	3x Carrion Leech	6	Wave 7	1-2	3x Ruin Stalker	10	Wave 11	1-2	3x Razorhowl Reaper	14
	3-4	2x Toxin Spitter			3-4	2x Ashline Gunner			3-4	2x Graveward Sentinel	
	5	2x Blight Herald			5	2x Dustborn Thrall			5	2x Last-Light Executioner	
	6	1x Ruin Stalker			6	1x Razorhowl Reaper			6	2x Last-Light Executioner	
Wave 4	1-2	3x Carrion Leech	10	Wave 8	1-2	3x Ruin Stalker	14	Wave 12	1-2	3x Razorhowl Reaper	18
	3-4	2x Toxin Spitter			3-4	2x Ashline Gunner			3-4	2x Graveward Sentinel	
	5	2x Blight Herald			5	2x Dustborn Thrall			5-6	2x Last-Light Executioner	
	6	1x Ashline Gunner			6	1x Graveward Sentinel			+ 1 Random Boss		
	+ 1 Random Boss				+ 1 Random Boss						

TURN EVENTS

At the start of each Turn, roll **2D6** to determine a special event for the Turn. If the Wave is in **Containment Breach** mode (Wave is in Turn 5 or later), do not roll Turn Events and use the Enemy Reinforcements event instead.

2: Second Wind

A Downed Unit returns as Standing with **1 HIT** remaining.

3: Field Dressing

One Standing Player Unit regains 1 lost **HIT**.

4: Opportunity

One Player Unit may immediately spend up to **2 ACT** on actions before the start of the Turn. This does not count as that Unit's activation for the Turn.

5: Supply Drop

Place 3 crates in random places on the board. If a crate lands on a Unit, immediately treat it as a "Booby Trap" crate and deal damage accordingly. Do not place that crate on the battlefield.

6: Strategic Command

Player Squad gains **+2 TO**.

7: Relentless Advance

The Horde presses on (no special event this Turn).

8: Scrambled Comms

Player Squad loses **-2 TO** (minimum 0).

9: Encroaching Threat

Each time a Horde Unit performs a Move Action during this Turn, it may move 1 additional Pace.

10: Enemy Reinforcements

Roll **1D6** and Spawn Horde Units according to the Wave table for this Wave.

11: Coordinated Assault

Horde Units have **+1 ACT** this Turn.

12: Overrun

All Horde Units immediately perform 1 Action according to their Behavior.

WAVE OBJECTIVES

Wave Objectives are optional bonuses; failure does not end the Wave.

At the start of each Wave, roll **1D6** to determine the Wave's Objective. If a Wave Objective is not completed by the end of the Wave, that Wave Objective is failed.

OBJECTIVES

1: Battlefield Control

Victory: At the end of the Wave, there is at least one Standing Player Unit on the NW, NE, SW, and SE Tiles.

2: Destroy Nexus

Setup: Place 3 Nexus markers as close as possible to the center of the West, Center, and East Tiles.

Special: Nexus Markers are items with **ARM 3** and **HIT 2** and can be targeted in combat.

Victory: All Nexus Markers Taken Out by the end of the Wave.

3: Overwhelming Force

Victory: End the Wave within 2 Turns.

4: Protect The Asset

Setup: Place an Asset marker as close as possible to the Center of a random Tile (excluding the player deployment Tile). Assets are Items with **ARM 4 HIT 4**.

Special: Horde Units will always prioritize targeting the Asset instead of Player Units in combat.

Victory: The Asset still has at least **1 HIT** at the end of the Wave.

5: Suppression Field

Setup: Place 3 Disruptor Pylons as close as possible to the center of three random Tiles.

Mission Action - Calibrate Pylon (2ACT): A Unit that Controls a Pylon calibrates it. Remove that Pylon from the battlefield.

Victory: All 3 Pylons have been calibrated.

6: The Artifact

Setup: Place 3 Search Markers in the center of three random Tiles.

Mission Action - Search (2ACT): A Unit that Controls a Search Marker searches it. Roll **1D6**: On a 1 or 2, the Artifact is found. This roll cannot be modified or re-rolled using TO.

Victory: The Artifact is found.

REWARDS

Once a Wave Objective's Victory condition is met, the Player Squad immediately selects one reward from the list below:

- **+4 MP**
- **+4 TO**. If this Wave Objective's Victory is determined at the end of the Wave, those TO are given in the first Turn of the next Wave, after resolving Turn events.
- One Downed Unit immediately returns to Standing with **1 HIT** remaining.
- One Standing Unit immediately gains one Spoil of War
- **1D3** Player Units perform a free Move action

PURCHASING UPGRADES

At the end of each Wave, you may spend your earned Mission Points on upgrades.

MP are gained in the following ways:

- Completing waves
- Completing Wave Objectives
- Opening a Crate and rolling "Stockpile"

UPGRADES:

- **Ammunition (2 MP):**
One Unit's Limited (**LIM**) weapon or "once per mission" ability can be used one additional time
- **Heal (4MP):**
One Unit immediately regains up to 2 lost **HIT**
- **Grenade (4 MP):**
One Unit gains a Grenade that can be used once for **1 ACT**: Throw grenade within 3 Paces. Deals 3 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent Units.
- **Medpack (4MP):**
One Unit gains a Medpack that can be used once for **1 ACT**: The Unit or a Squadmate it Controls regains **1D3** lost **HIT**.
- **Turret (6 MP):**
One Unit gains a portable Turret it can place once for **1 ACT**: Place Turret Adjacent to Unit. Player Units that Control the Turret can use it instead of their Ranged Weapon(s) when performing a Ranged Combat attack, using **ATT 4 SKL 5**. When using the Turret, draw Line of Sight from the Turret instead of the active Unit. No **ACT** penalty for multiple uses in same activation. Remove the Turret from the battlefield once it has been used 5 times.
- **Spoil Of War (8 MP):**
One Standing Unit gains one Spoil Of War
- **Reinforcements (8 MP):**
One Downed Unit returns to Standing with all its **HIT** remaining
- **Battlefield Chirurgy (8 MP):**
Remove one Injury from one Standing Unit

CRATES

Crate contents are unknown until they are opened. Crates are items with **ARM 3 HIT 1** and can be targeted in combat. If a crate reaches 0 **HIT**, it causes an explosion dealing 3 Damage to all Adjacent Units, then remove it from the battlefield.

Mission Action - Open Crate (1 ACT): A Unit that Controls a Crate opens it. Roll to determine its contents, then remove that Crate from the battlefield.

1: Stockpile

Player Squad gains +3 MP.

2: Command Uplink

Player Squad gains +2 TO.

3: Map

One Standing Player Unit may immediately perform a free Move action.

4: Relay Order

One Standing Player Unit may immediately perform a free Basic or Mission action for **1 ACT**.

5: Upgrade

Select and apply one free Upgrade of your choice (see "Upgrades" above).

6: Booby Trap

Causes an explosion dealing 3 Damage to all Adjacent Units.

HORDE UNITS

1. CARRION LEECH

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 1	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Latch (2MC)		3	3
SKILLS			
Behavior		Swift	
Behavior: • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible Swift: Each time this Unit performs the Dash action, it costs one less ACT. This means that the first time this Unit performs a Dash in each of its Activations, it costs zero ACT.			
Carrion Leech 10GP		FV: 1 XP: 0	

2. TOXIN SPITTER

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 1	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Claws		2	3
 Spit Toxins (2RC BLS)		3	3
SKILLS			
Behavior			
Behavior: - If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. - If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. - Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit - Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit			
Toxin Spitter 10GP		FV: 1 XP: 0	

3. BLIGHT HERALD

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 1	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Blight		3	3
 Spore Cloud		3	3
SKILLS			
Behavior			
Behavior: - If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat (once per activation) - If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units - If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. - Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit - Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit			
Blight Herald 10GP		FV: 1 XP: 0	

4. RUIN STALKER

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 2	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Bone Claws (2MC RLT)		4	4
SKILLS			
Behavior		Swift	
Behavior: • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible Swift: Each time this Unit performs the Dash action, it costs one less ACT. This means that the first time this Unit performs a Dash in each of its Activations, it costs zero ACT.			
Ruin Stalker 20GP		FV: 2 XP: 0	

5. ASHLINE GUNNER

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 2	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Fists		2	3
 Rust Rifle (2RC)		4	4
SKILLS			
Behavior			
Behavior: - If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. - If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. - Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit - Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit			
Ashline Gunner 20GP		FV: 2 XP: 0	

6. DUSTBORN THRALL

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 2	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Ritual Daggers (2MC RND1)		4	4
 Shard Volley (BLS)		4	4
SKILLS			
Behavior			
Behavior: - If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat (once per activation) - If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units - If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. - Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit - Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit			
Dustborn Thrall 20GP		FV: 2 XP: 0	

7. RAZORHOWL REAVER

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 4		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
Hooked Cleaver (2MC RND1)		4	5	
SKILLS				
Behavior	Swift			
Behavior: • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move to be adjacent to closest enemy Unit • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible Swift: Each time this Unit performs the Dash action, it costs one less ACT. This means that the first time this Unit performs a Dash in each of its Activations, it costs zero ACT.				
Razorhowl Reaver 30GP		FV: 3 XP: 0		

8. GRAVEWARD SENTINEL

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 4		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
Scrap Shiv		3	3	
Grave Cannon (2RC BLS)		4	5	
SKILLS				
Behavior				
Behavior: • If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units. • If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. • Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit • Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit				
Graveward Sentinel 30GP		FV: 3 XP: 0		

9. LAST-LIGHT EXECUTIONER

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 4		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
Judgement Axe (2MC RLT CHR1)		4	5	
Condemnor Bolt (ACC1)		4	5	
SKILLS				
Behavior				
Behavior: • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat (once per activation) • If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units • If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat. • Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit • Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit				
Last-Light Executioner 30GP		FV: 3 XP: 0		

10. BOSS: SHADOW FIEND

ACT 4	ARM 4	HIT 8		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
Twilight Blades* (2MC BLD1)		4	5	
SKILLS				
Boss Spawn	Behavior			
Phasebound	Counter			
Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as far as possible from any enemy Units, not visible, or at least in Cover. Behavior: Each time this Unit moves, if there is at least one non-visible enemy Unit, place this Unit Adjacent to a random non-visible enemy. If all enemies are visible, this Unit moves normally. • If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat. • Move toward a random non-visible enemy Unit (if any), to cover if possible • Move toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible • Dash toward closest enemy Unit, to cover if possible Phasebound: This Unit is always considered to be in Cover. Counter: Each time this Unit is the primary target of a Melee Attack, if this Unit did not lose any HIT by the end of that Combat, it may immediately perform a Melee Attack against the original Attacker.				
<i>The Shadow Stalker is rarely seen until it strikes, slipping through light and shadow with unnatural precision. It never lingers on a single target, vanishing after each attack and reappearing elsewhere in a calculated pattern of violence. By the time its prey can react, it has already moved on.</i>				
Boss: Shadow Fiend 50GP		FV: 5 XP: 0		

11. BOSS: OSSUARY ENGINE

ACT 4	ARM 4	HIT 8	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Bonegrind Actuators (RLT)		4	5
 Hull Breach Cannon (2RC BLS)		4	4
SKILLS			
Boss Spawn		Behavior	
Null Construct			

Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as close as possible to the center of a random tile. All Adjacent enemies immediately take 2 Melee damage.

Behavior:

- If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat (once per activation)
- If this Unit is Adjacent to an enemy Unit, Dash or Move away from all enemy Units
- If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat.
- Move to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit
- Dash to cover with Line of Sight on an enemy Unit

Null Construct: This Unit cannot be targeted in Ranged combat if it has all of its HIT.

The Ossuary Engine advances with grinding inevitability, a towering fusion of dead machinery and ossified flesh. Layers of bone and corroded plating absorb incoming fire until something vital is breached. When it finally bleeds, sparks and marrow spill together as the Engine responds with cold, methodical force.

Boss: Ossuary Engine 50GP

FV: 5 XP: 0

12. BOSS: BROODMIND

ACT 4	ARM 4	HIT 8	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Claws (2MC RND1)		4	5
 Spew (BLS)		4	4
SKILLS			
Boss Spawn		Behavior	
Nutrient Lash		Spawn Sacs	

Boss Spawn: This Unit spawns as close as possible to the center of the center tile. All Adjacent enemies immediately take 2 Melee damage.

Behavior:

- If there are no Adjacent enemy Units, spawn one Carrion Leech Adjacent to this Unit (once per activation)
- If there is a valid Melee target, attack that target in Melee combat.
- If there is a valid Ranged target, attack that target in Ranged combat
- Move away from all enemy Units, to cover if possible
- Dash away from all enemy Units, to cover if possible

Spawn Sacs: Each time this Unit is the target of melee combat and does not lose any HIT as a result of that combat, spawn one Carrion Leech Adjacent to it.

Nutrient Lash: Each time any Player Unit within 3 Paces loses 1 or more HIT in melee combat, roll 1D6. On a 1 or 2, this Unit regains 1 lost HIT.

The Broodmind dominates the battlefield through sheer biological excess, its swollen mass spawning lesser horrors in an endless tide. It does not rush the fight but overwhelms it, filling every gap with living weapons guided by a single, oppressive will. Left unchecked, it turns survival into a war of attrition that cannot be won.

Boss: Broodmind 50GP

FV: 5 XP: 0